

Shyam Selvadurai's *Funny Boy*: A Paragon of Queer Representation

Throughout the country, don't-say-gay laws are passed, drag queen story hours are protested, and queer literature is censored. That is why it's so important for students to be exposed to diverse literature, which Hunter College High School originally did through 7th grade's *Funny Boy* by Shyam Selvadurai. Unfortunately, the novel was pulled from the curriculum after criticism about its appropriateness. But *Funny Boy* is a crucial part of our education and should be reintroduced. Not teaching this book is sending students into the world blindfolded: exposure to intersectional queer stories like *Funny Boy* is key to their ability to contribute to global society as well as teachers' ability to promote a safe learning environment.

The text is essential to the learning and success of students as members of society due to being Hunter's only offering with both queer and South Asian representation. A survey revealed that 90.3% of students have not read a queer-focused story outside of *Funny Boy* at Hunter, and 75% can say the same for works with a focus on South Asian people. Thus, Selvadurai's perspective, which incorporates queer, low-income, and South Asian stories, is necessary. He tackles a variety of social issues, from growing up queer in an intolerant country to the conflict between Tamil and Sinhalese communities in the 1980s, with empathy. History informs the present, and according to queer educator R.B. Brooks, "Many of the issues LGBTQ+ communities face today are long-standing struggles. Knowing more about the root causes of disparities LGBTQ+ individuals face in areas like housing, jobs, education, and rights can illuminate ways to advocate for change today."¹ Furthermore, *Funny Boy* can help young people discover themselves and affirm their realities. One anonymous student commented that "Queer

¹ R.B. Brooks, "The Importance of Queer Studies," BestColleges, Last Updated January 25, 2022, <https://www.bestcolleges.com/blog/what-is-queer-studies/>.

representation is key in novels, especially in seventh grade when middle schoolers begin to figure themselves out.”

However, students are not the only beneficiaries of queer education: teachers also gain a broader understanding of LGBTQ+ issues, thus creating a safer and more effective learning environment. By reading a book like *Funny Boy*, teachers are able to address structural issues through a queer lens. In the story, Selvadurai reframes historical conflict through Arjie and other’s experiences as queer teens, and those unique perspectives help teachers effectively educate about historical LGBTQ+ and South Asian struggles. Moreover, focusing on a narrative like *Funny Boy* for an extended period of time would stop the tokenization of LGBTQ+ students, creating an environment that allows them to grow without being used as a case study for their peers. These new conditions would benefit teachers as well because they would be able to facilitate more productive conversations rather than surface-level, stigma-laden ones. Thus, teachers would achieve a more productive classroom environment.

Some argue that *Funny Boy* should have been cut because it was inappropriate for 7th graders due to a sexual scene between two minors. However, there are a couple solutions to this issue that should be explored rather than resorting to a ban. First, a simple trigger warning for that page can allow students who are uncomfortable to opt out while still understanding what happened. Second, teachers can work with health educators to ensure that students have the necessary background knowledge to grasp what’s going on.

Exposing students to *Funny Boy* is important. It benefits them by illuminating methods of advocacy, furthering their understanding of queer issues, and affirming the realities of LGBTQ+ students. It helps teachers by facilitating a more productive learning environment. To ban books

like Shyam Selvadurai's *Funny Boy* is not only to erase the stories of real people but also to send students into the world needlessly blind.